

WHS Guidelines - Uttarayan



Introduction

Agenda:

- This session is to discuss a few key WHS areas of risk relevant to Uttarayan, but also for ongoing mandir activities.
- Each centre would be having is own existing systems, so this serves as a guide to align on baseline practices and is designed to be adaptable for each centre’s use cases.
- Our objective is to ensure that WHS compliance is maintained at all times so that BAPS can host events that are as safe but enjoyable as possible.



Planning and Co-ordination

- WHS plans should be finalised at least 2 months before the event, or at the earliest possible time.
- Event location and key details must be confirmed early (ideally 2 months before) for planning and co-ordination purposes. This is of key importance, particularly when engaging with external parties and endorsing our insurance policies.
- All WHS-related decisions must be communicated to the designated leads and volunteers should not make hasty decisions independently without consulting them first.
- Establish clear roles and responsibilities for all safety personnel before any event.



Equipment Setup & Safety

- Ensure volunteers in Uttarayan setup/wind-up are wearing appropriate PPE.
- Ensure appropriate safety measures are followed when using ladders and any tools/equipments.
- All electrical equipment, cables, plugs, etc. must meet appropriate safety standards. Proper cable management should be conducted to prevent tripping hazards.
- Use proper outdoor-rated equipment for external events (weatherproof where necessary).
- If there is any specialised equipment that is used, it should **only** be operated by qualified volunteers.



Emergency Plan (incl. Vehicles)

- Emergencies can occur anytime, anywhere and require immediate attention and preparation.
- There should be at least 4 full-time First-Aid Officers rostered and present (with a Green First Aid Vest) at any given time to tend to such emergencies (2 male and 2 female, ideally). These volunteers **should not** be involved in other seva departments. A dedicated First-Aid marquee/area should be clearly marked on event maps/signage.
- If an issue has been identified by a First-Aid Officer, they should call and inform:
    - 000,
    - any medical professionals on-site (if required),
    - the Mandir Co-Ordinator
    - and the front security with the location details of the emergency. Security can also assist with crowd control.
- An emergency can also be identified by a bystander, who can call 000, hence, all specified people above should be prepared in case emergency vehicles do arrive unexpectedly.
- Upon arrival of the emergency vehicles, front security should direct them through the mandir premises to the location of the emergency.
- An empty room on mandir premises should be available to treat the patient in private. For outdoor events, ideally a marquee setup with essential requirements.
- Access to wheelchairs should also be available.





Emergency Evacuation Plan

- All mandirs should have an emergency assembly point which all WHS leads & volunteers should be aware of.
- For larger events, respective departmental leads should also be made aware of the assembly point and emergency evacuation plan.
- If the emergency evacuation point is where we are conducting the activities, then we need to come up with an alternate emergency assembly point.
- Please ensure that emergency evacuation doors, corridors (including fire-exits) are unlocked and clear of any obstacles. The plans should also be printed and shown around the mandir premises.
- In the event of an emergency, all designated leads and volunteers, especially sabha vyasastha and security volunteers should guide people to the emergency assembly point.
- Please work with your local WHS leads & volunteers to ensure this plan is thoroughly discussed and if possible rehearsed. This discussion can also be added to regular admin/coordinator meetings to onboard new volunteers if necessary and keep this topic in the forefront.
- When hosting events in external indoor venues, such as community halls, we should learn the specific emergency evacuation plans for that location.



Weather Contingency

- Back-up plans must be prepared for adverse weather conditions.
- Coordinate with relevant departments, such as decoration, sabha vyavastha, security to accommodate indoor events.
- Ensure emergency corridors and doors remain accessible regardless of weather plans.



Kite Flying Safety

- If children want to fly kites, they **must** be accompanied by an adult **at all times**.
- Kite flying should only be conducted in designated safe areas, away from power lines, roads and other infrastructure.
- Establish clear boundaries, if possible, for kite flying zones with appropriate signage and barriers where necessary.
- Consider collection of kites that are ripped or have fallen to the ground to avoid tripping hazards.



String Safety & Management

- Hand/finger protection should be available (either for sale, or free) for all participants to prevent cuts.
- Used/broken strings must be collected and disposed of properly – loose strings pose serious hazards. Designate volunteers for collection of loose/fallen strings in the area.
- First-Aid officers must be on standby in this area, ensuring their kits have treatments for cuts/lacerations as well as the regular bandage equipment. They should also not be involved in any other seva.



Food Stalls

- We should consider allergen requirements of the attendees. Volunteers at these stalls should ask for consent beforehand.
- Menus/signs for Shayona food stalls should contain basic allergen alerts, such as presence of nuts/gluten, etc. and include a clause to encourage attendees to inform volunteers of specific allergies.
- Volunteers in the kitchen/Shayona food stalls should be wearing gloves, hairnets, and other such hygiene equipment. Food that is leftover at the end should also be disposed and **not** carried over to the next day.



Crowd Management

- Plan appropriate crowd flow for the venue size and expected attendance.
- Ensure adequate space for movement, especially in high-traffic areas.
- Consider entry/exit points and their capacity.
- Separate kite-flying areas from general congregation/food areas where possible to minimise risk.